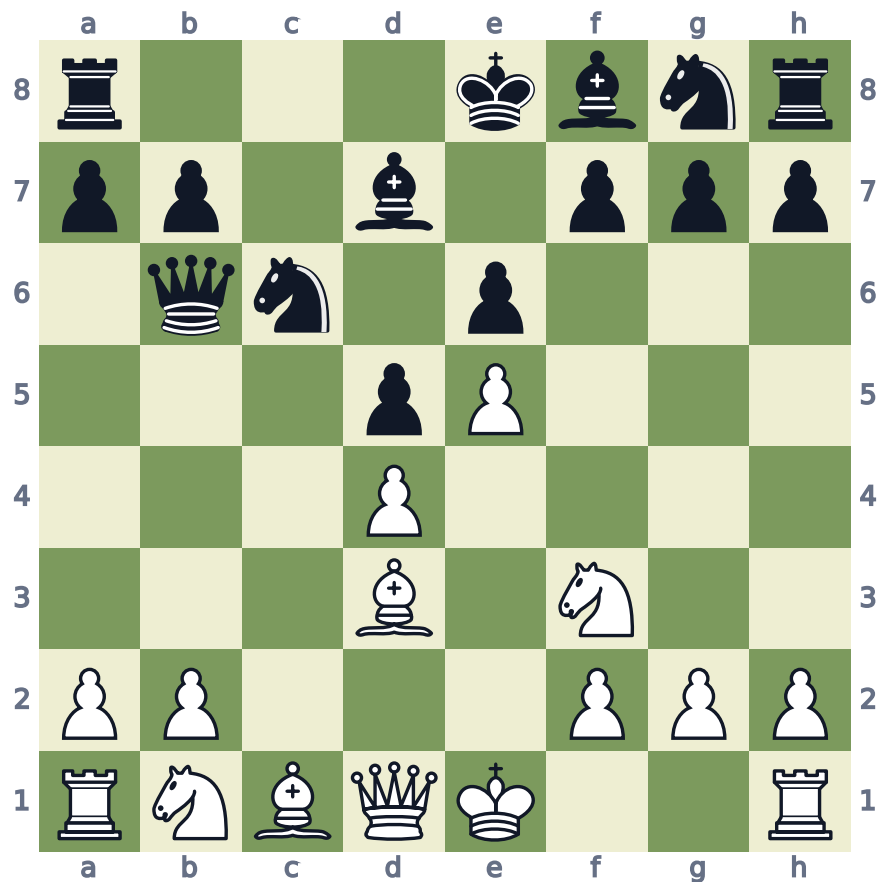


French Defense Advance Repertoire

Pawn-chain play, pressure on d4, c5 and f6 breaks, and the locked c8 bishop



Meet the French with 3.e5, defend the pawn chain efficiently, and create kingside or queenside play from a clear structural map.

8 learning units | diagrams | recall tests | engine-checked analysis

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Meet the French with 3.e5, defend the pawn chain efficiently, and create kingside or queenside play from a clear structural map.

THE TRAINING LOOP

- First identify Black's defense from pawn placement and move order.
- At every diagram, name the center, the urgent threat, and two candidate moves.
- Hide the recall answer until you have spoken the move and its purpose.
- Replay each line from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected White repertoire. It covers the main structural and move-order decisions you need for practical play; the PGN companion makes later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

The e5-d4 chain points White toward the kingside.

PRINCIPLE 2

Black attacks the base with ...c5 and later ...f6.

PRINCIPLE 3

c3 supports d4 but slows the b1 knight.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

The c8 bishop is Black's problem until the structure changes.

PRINCIPLE 5

White must not defend d4 passively forever.

PRINCIPLE 6

Pawn-chain rules guide plans, but tactics decide the timing of breaks.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

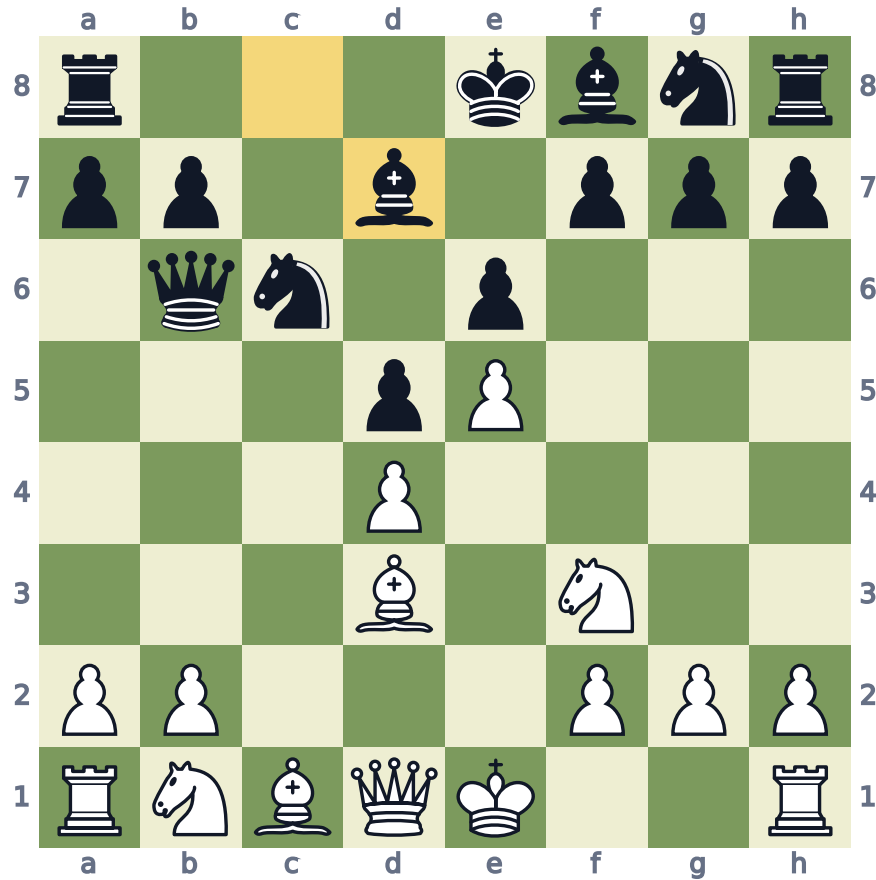
- | | | |
|-----------|------------------------------------|---|
| 01 | Advance French core | Count d4 attackers and defenders before every attacking move. |
|
 | | |
| 02 | French ...Nh6 | ...Nh6 often targets f5 and d4; do not exchange automatically. |
|
 | | |
| 03 | French ...Bd7 | ...Bd7 prepares ...Bb5 or ...Rc8 and completes development. |
|
 | | |
| 04 | French ...f6 break | When ...f6 arrives, decide whether to capture, support, or counter in the center. |
|
 | | |
| 05 | French 3...b6 | ...b6 solves the c8 bishop; decide whether to trade it. |
|
 | | |
| 06 | French early ...c5 | If Black attacks before ...d5, the center may resemble a Benoni. |
|
 | | |
| 07 | French Tarrasch alternative | Nd2 keeps the c-pawn free and supports e4, but blocks the c1 bishop. |
|
 | | |
| 08 | French Exchange awareness | The Exchange is not automatically dull; activity and move order still matter. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

Advance French core



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

WHITE'S IDEA

Support the center, develop, and prepare kingside play or queenside defense.

MAIN DANGER

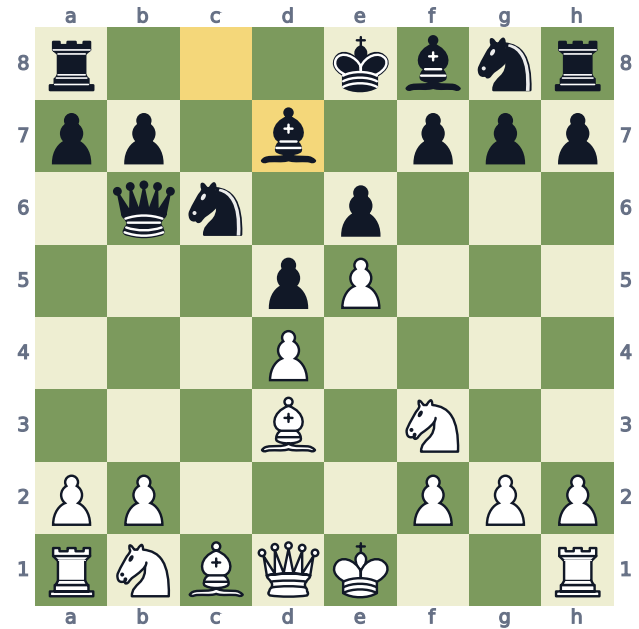
d4 is attacked repeatedly and can collapse tactically.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Count d4 attackers and defenders before every attacking move.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

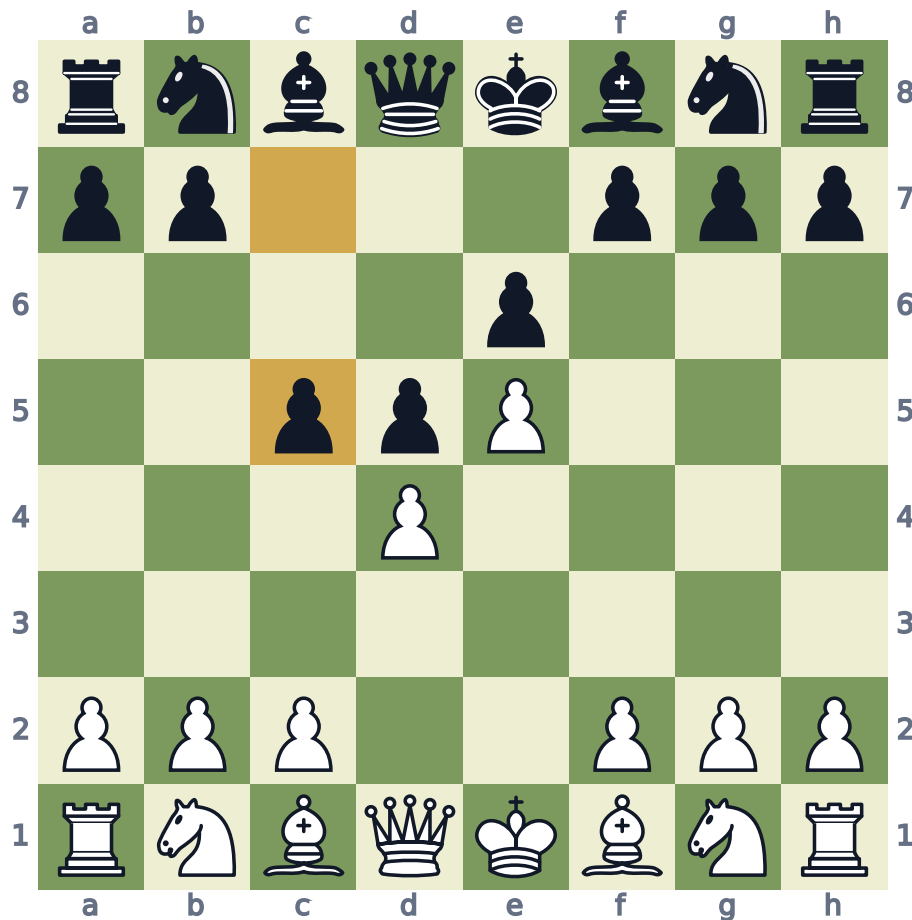
Position estimate: +0.04 for White (equal). Principal continuation: 1. O-O Nxd4 2. Nbd2 Nxf3+ 3. Nxf3 a5 4. a3 Bc5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

Advance French core



YOUR TASK

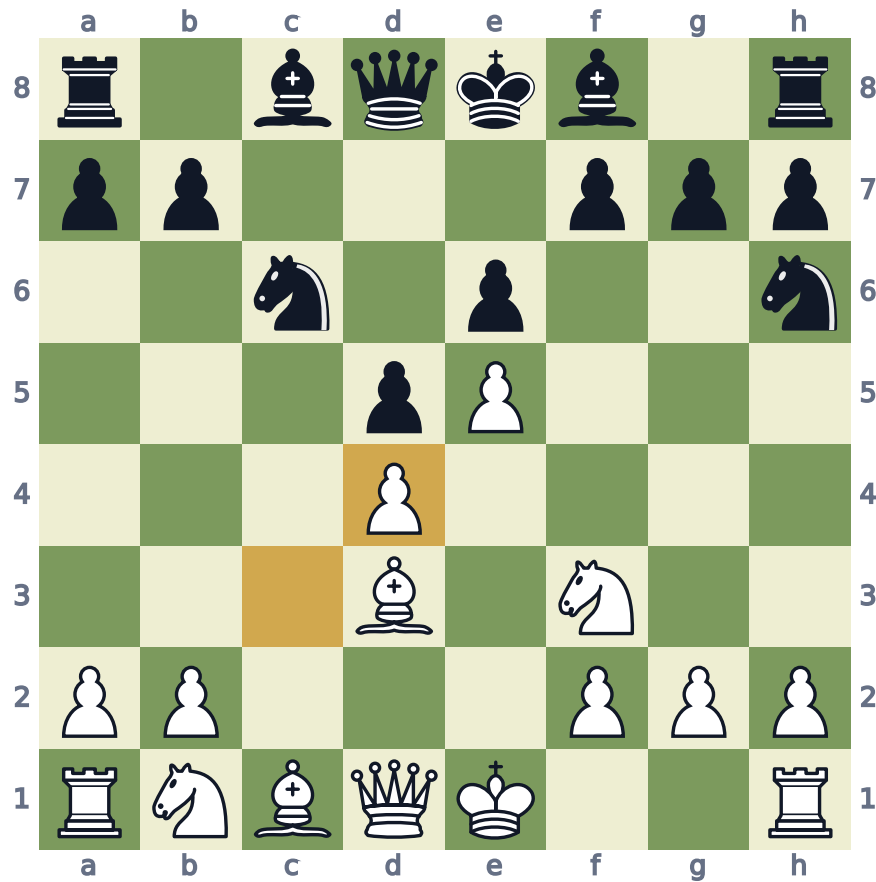
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

French ...Nh6



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Nh6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4

WHITE'S IDEA

Develop while Black reroutes the knight toward f5.

MAIN DANGER

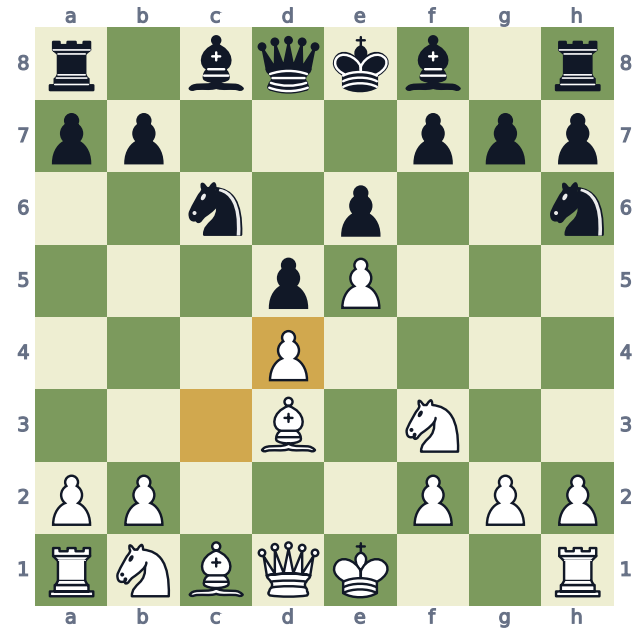
Bxh6 can help Black's queen and dark-square attack.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...Nh6 often targets f5 and d4; do not exchange automatically.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.31 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nf5 Bxf5 2. exf5 Nc3 3. h6 Ne2 4. g5 h4 5. Rg8 hxg5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

French ...Nh6



YOUR TASK

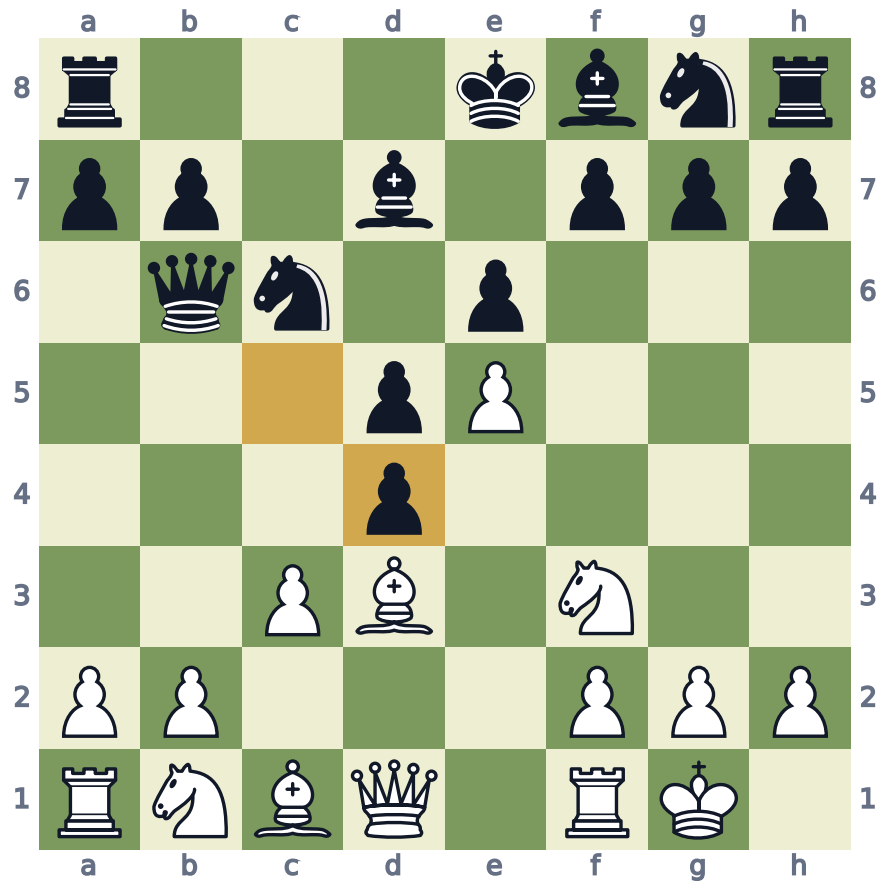
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

French ...Bd7



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 Bd7 7. O-O cxd4

WHITE'S IDEA

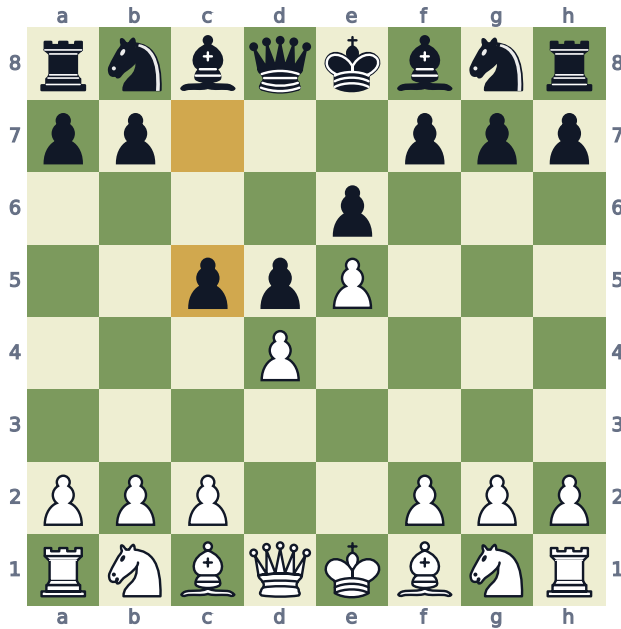
Castle and keep the center supported before choosing a recapture.

MAIN DANGER

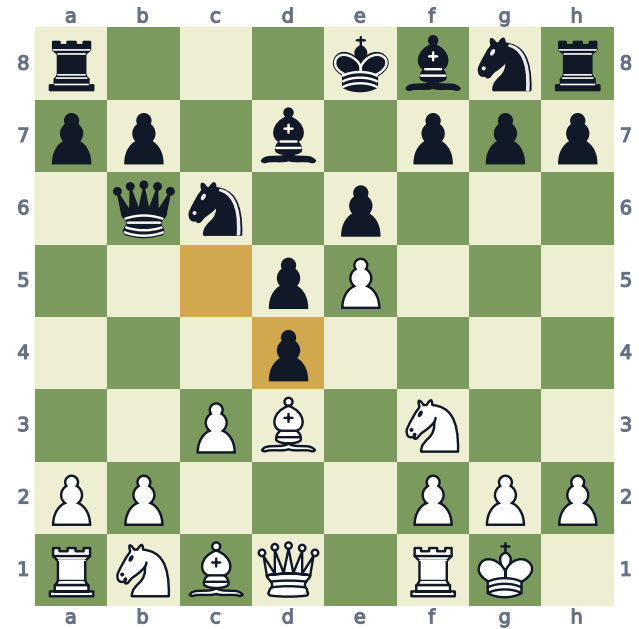
The d4 pawn can become isolated after exchanges.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...Bd7 prepares ...Bb5 or ...Rc8 and completes development.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. a3 Nge7 2. Re1 Ng6 3. h4 Be7

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

French ...Bd7



YOUR TASK

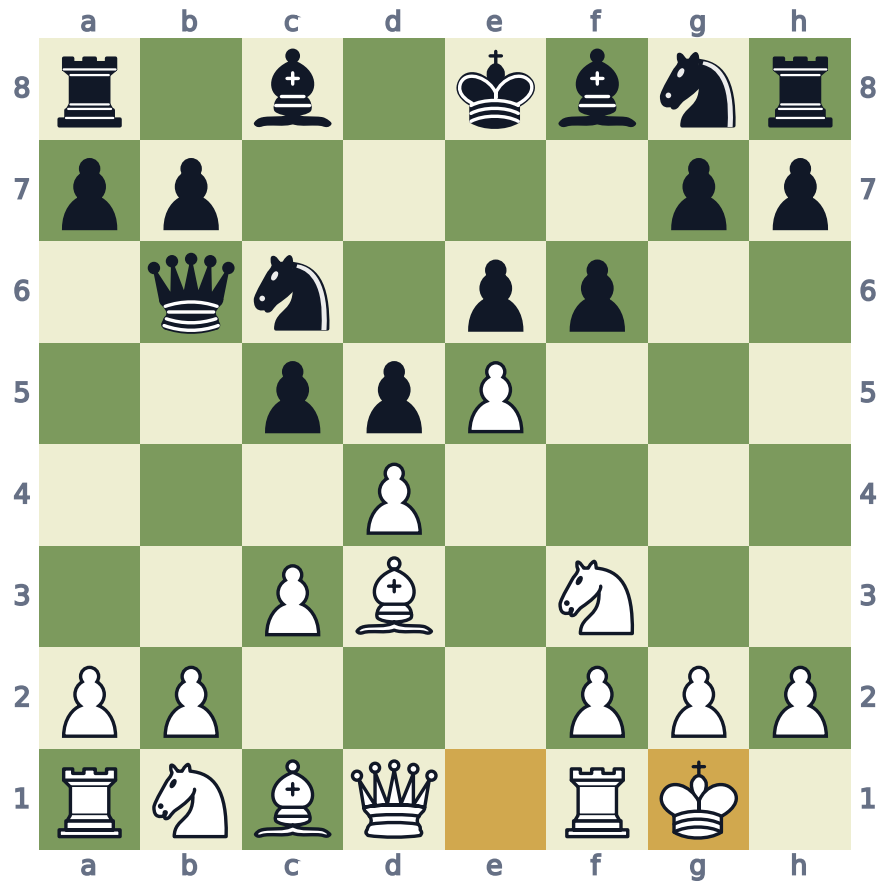
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

French ...f6 break



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 f6 7. O-O

WHITE'S IDEA

Meet the pawn-chain attack with calm development and calculate exf6.

MAIN DANGER

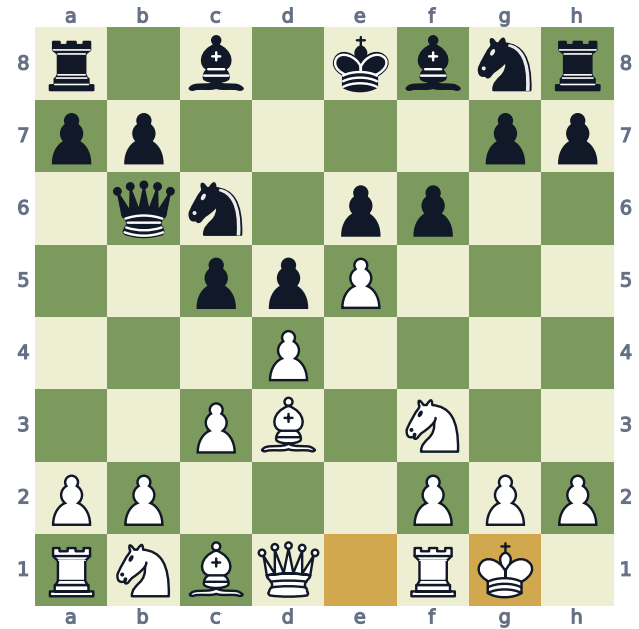
Opening the f-file can expose White's king or e5.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

When ...f6 arrives, decide whether to capture, support, or counter in the center.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

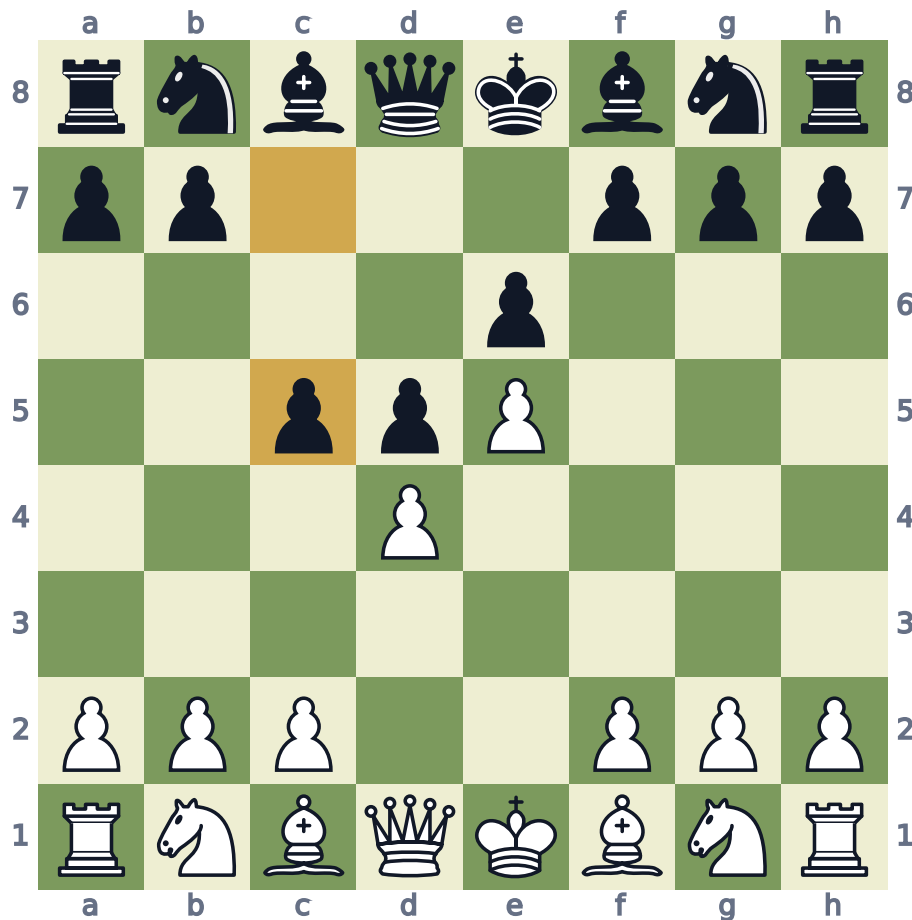
Position estimate: +1.07 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bd7 dxc5 2. Bxc5 b4 3. Be7 Re1 4. Nxe5 Nxe5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

French ...f6 break



YOUR TASK

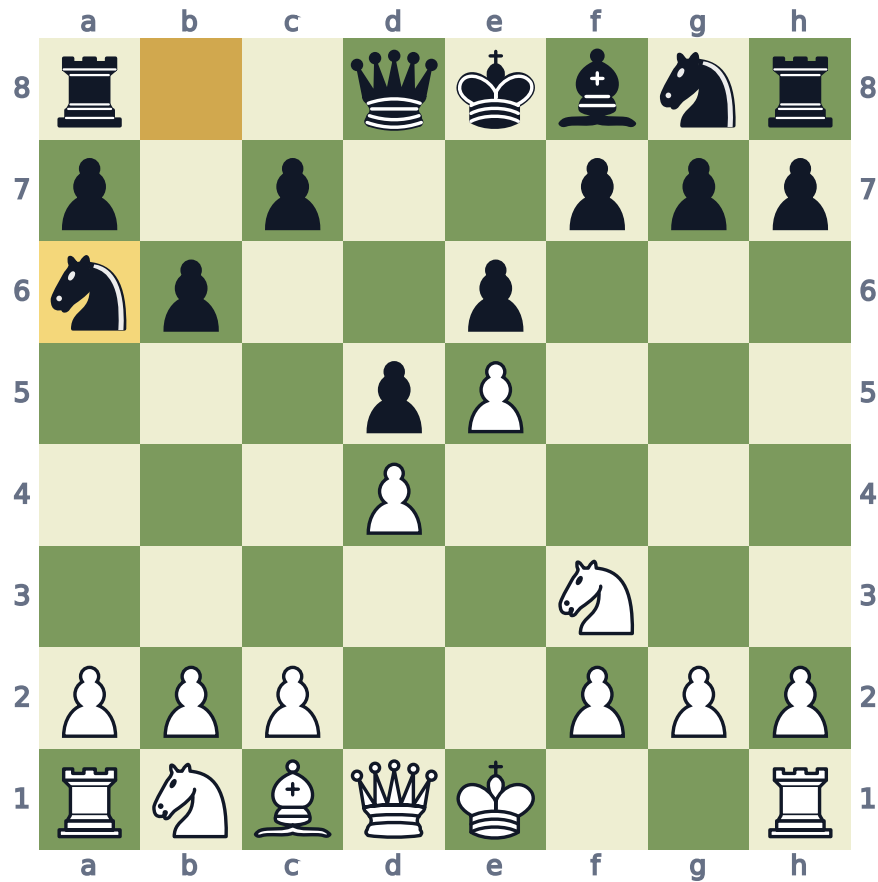
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

French 3...b6



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 b6 4. Nf3 Ba6 5. Bxa6 Nxa6

WHITE'S IDEA

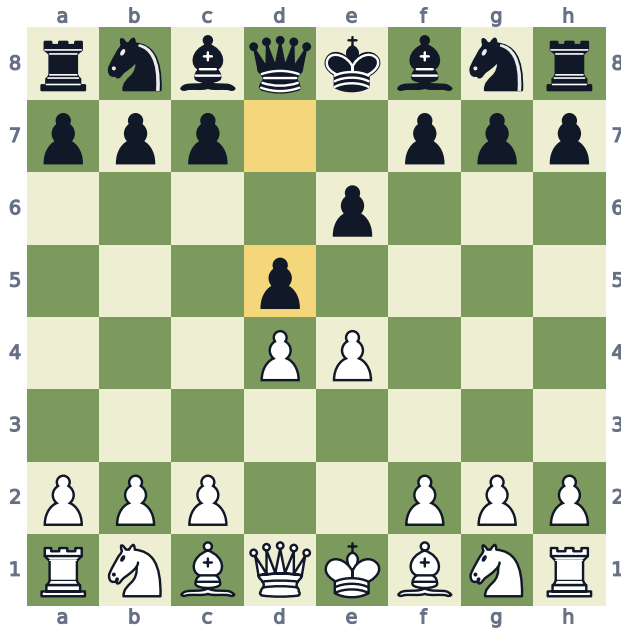
Exchange Black's active bishop and retain the space advantage.

MAIN DANGER

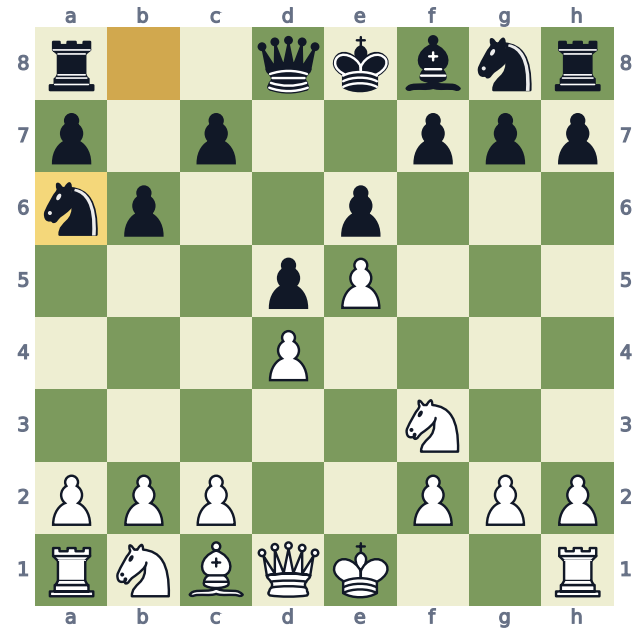
The a6 knight may reroute to b4 or c5 with tempo.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...b6 solves the c8 bishop; decide whether to trade it.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

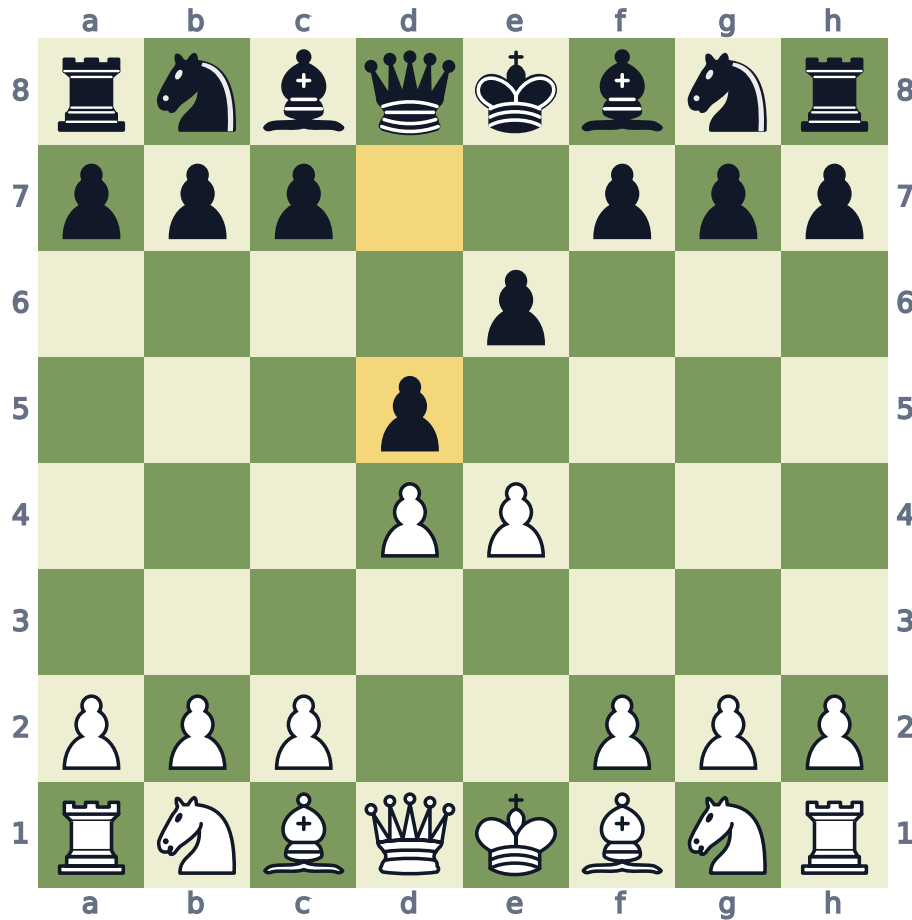
Position estimate: +1.09 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. c4 c6 2. Qa4 Qc8 3. cxd5 b5 4. Qd1 Bb4+ 5. Kf1 exd5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

French 3...b6



YOUR TASK

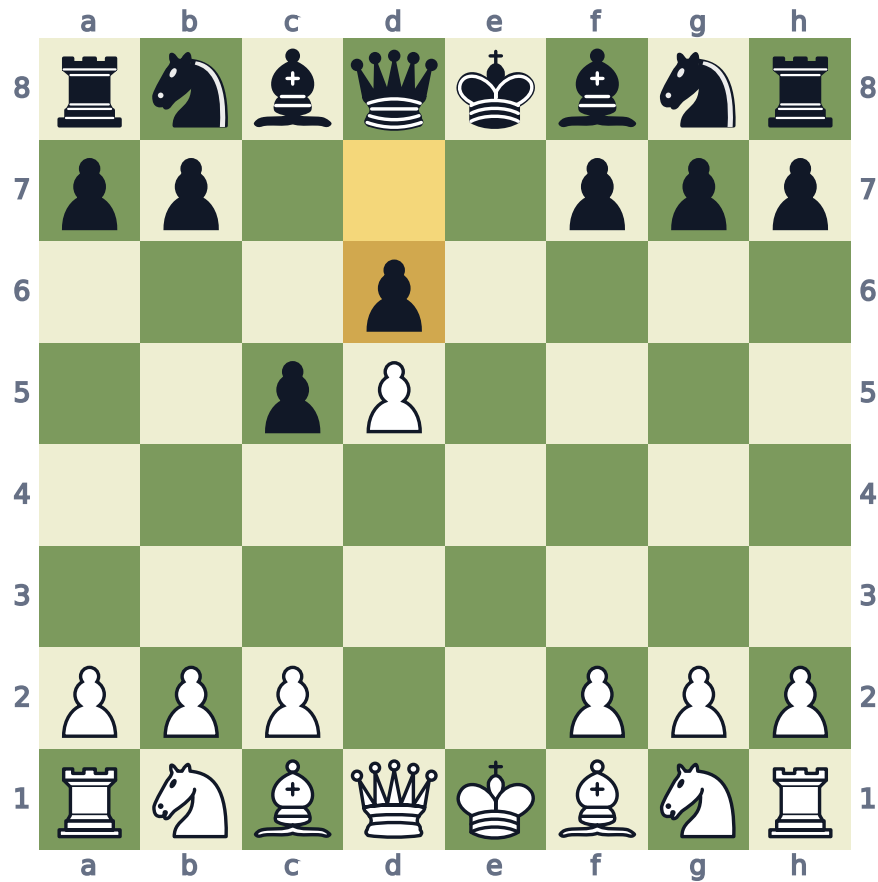
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

French early ...c5



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 c5 3. d5 exd5 4. exd5 d6

WHITE'S IDEA

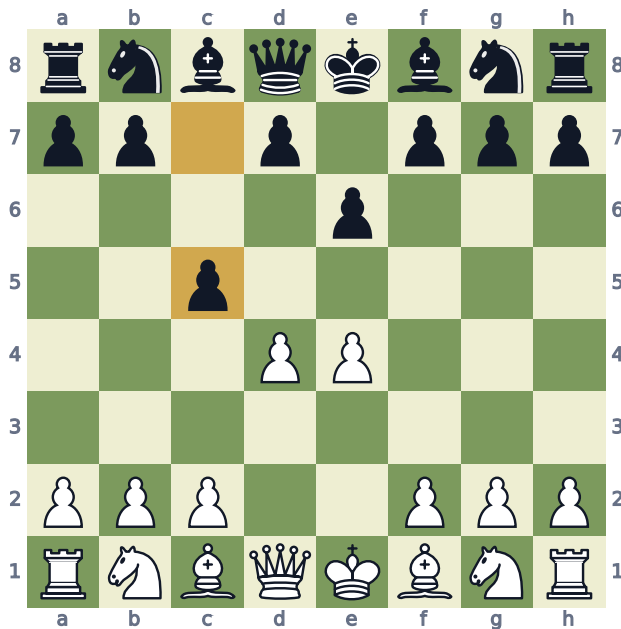
Use the space and advanced passer while completing development.

MAIN DANGER

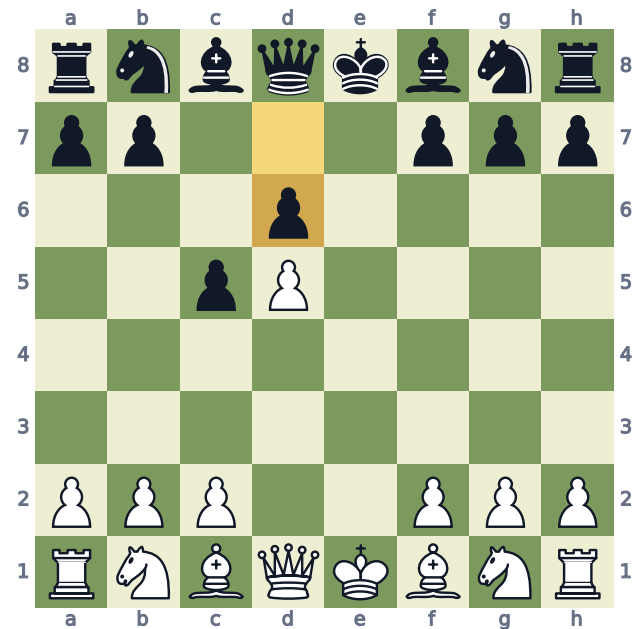
The d6 pawn can become blockaded and weak.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

If Black attacks before ...d5, the center may resemble a Benoni.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

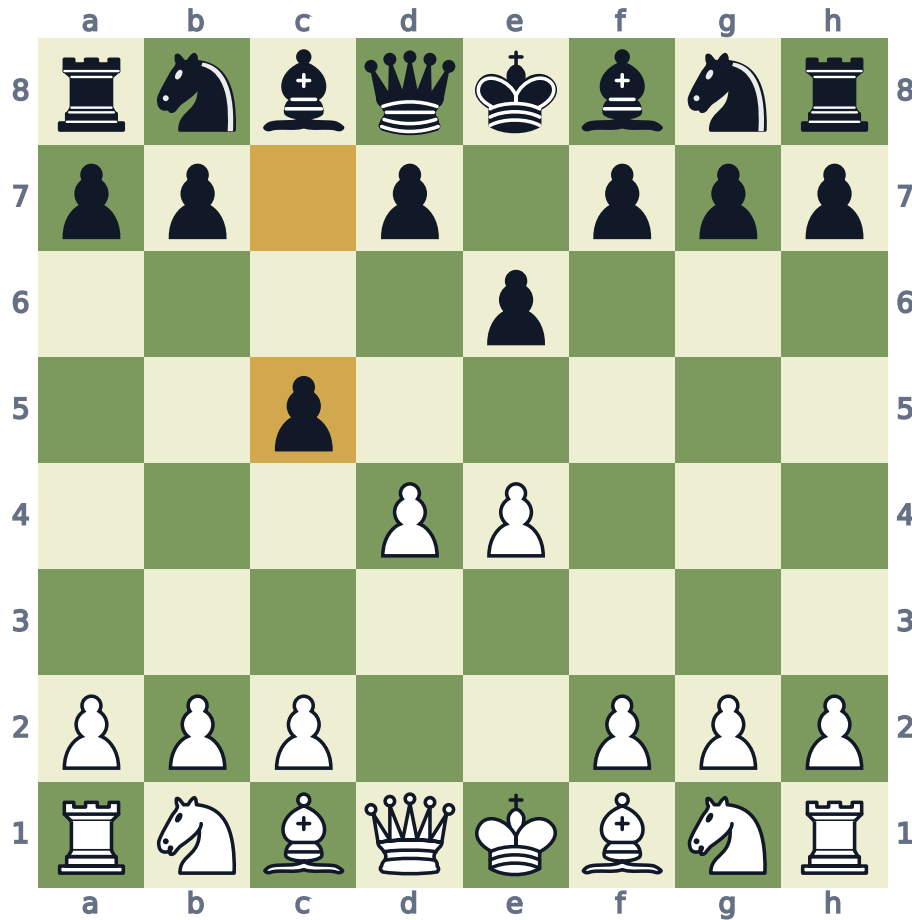
Position estimate: +0.83 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nf3 Be7 2. Bd3 Nf6 3. O-O O-O 4. c4 Bg4 5. h3 Bxf3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

French early ...c5



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

French Tarrasch alternative



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. e5 Nfd7 5. Bd3 c5 6. c3

WHITE'S IDEA

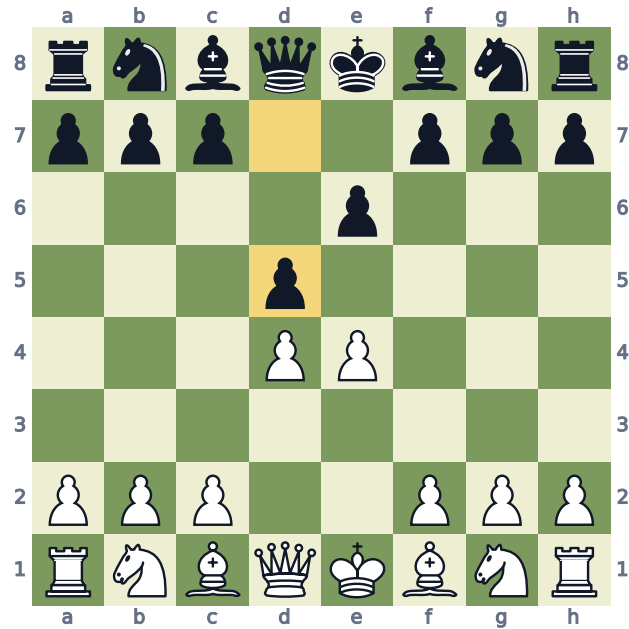
Understand a flexible alternative that avoids the Winawer pin.

MAIN DANGER

The d4 pawn remains Black's target.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Nd2 keeps the c-pawn free and supports e4, but blocks the c1 bishop.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

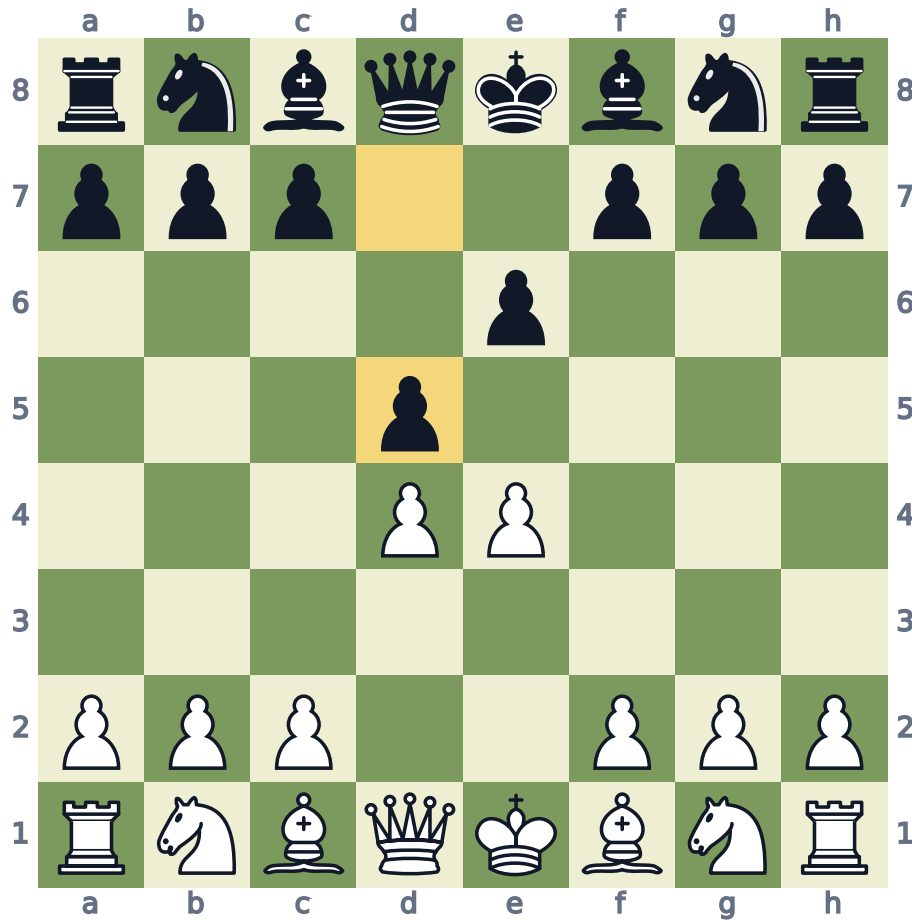
Position estimate: +0.68 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. cxd4 cxd4 2. Qb6 Ne2 3. Nc6 Nf3 4. f6 Be3 5. fxe5 dxe5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

French Tarrasch alternative



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

French Exchange awareness



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 exd5 4. Bd3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Bd6 6. O-O

WHITE'S IDEA

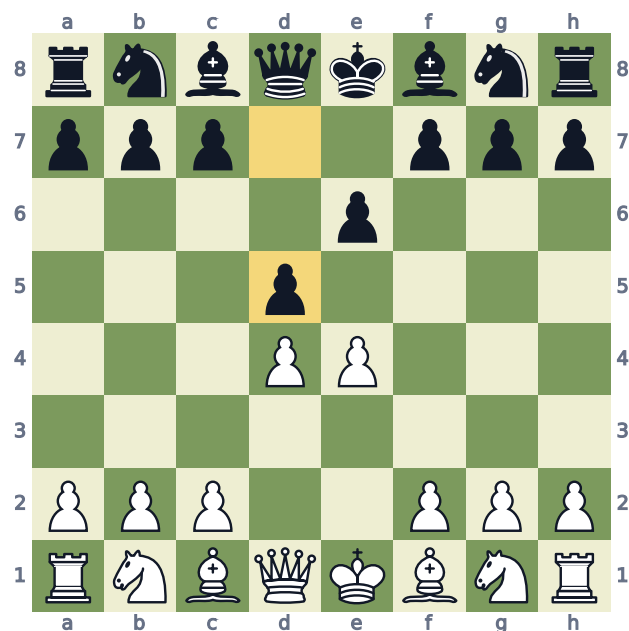
Use active piece placement to create imbalance in a symmetrical structure.

MAIN DANGER

Routine symmetry can surrender the initiative.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The Exchange is not automatically dull; activity and move order still matter.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

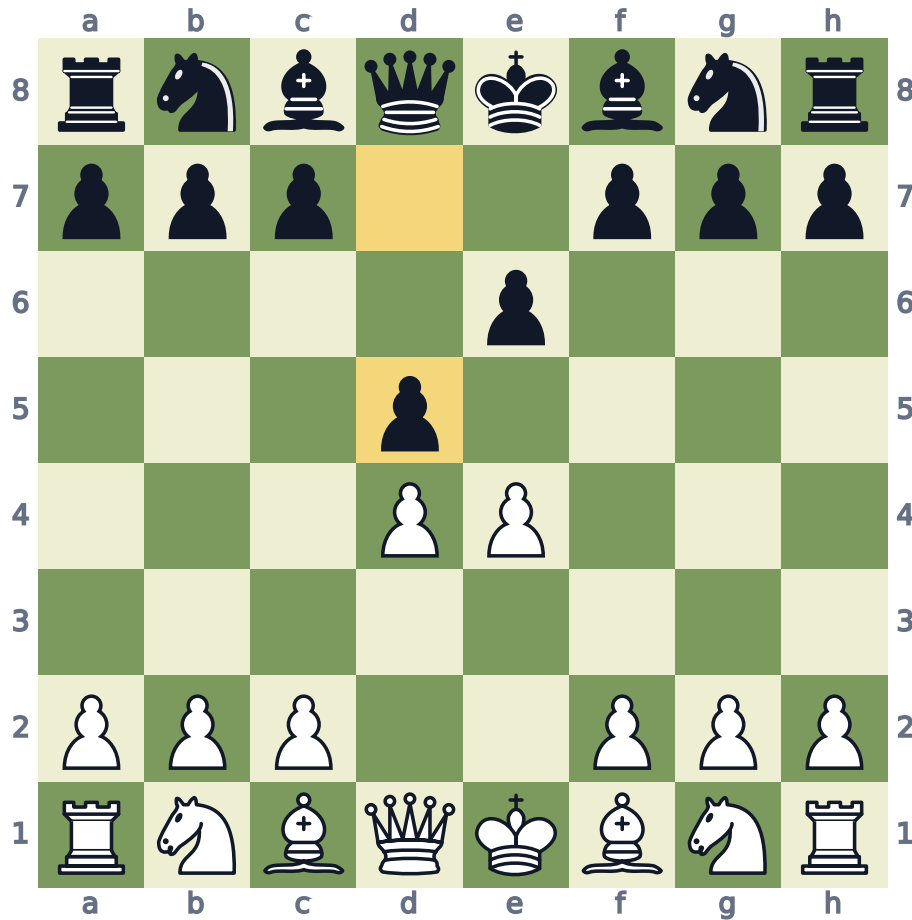
Position estimate: +0.17 for White (equal). Principal continuation: 1. O-O Bg5 2. Bg4 Re1 3. Nbd7 Nbd2 4. Re8 Rxe8+ 5. Qxe8 h3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

French Exchange awareness



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. ADVANCE FRENCH CORE

Course move: c3. Purpose: Support the center, develop, and prepare kingside play or queenside defense. Engine comparison: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4 (+0.33 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d4 is attacked repeatedly and can collapse tactically.

02. FRENCH ...NH6

Course move: c3. Purpose: Develop while Black reroutes the knight toward f5. Engine comparison: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4 (+0.33 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Bxh6 can help Black's queen and dark-square attack.

03. FRENCH ...BD7

Course move: c3. Purpose: Castle and keep the center supported before choosing a recapture. Engine comparison: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4 (+0.33 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The d4 pawn can become isolated after exchanges.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. FRENCH ...F6 BREAK

Course move: c3. Purpose: Meet the pawn-chain attack with calm development and calculate exf6. Engine comparison: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4 (+0.33 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Opening the f-file can expose White's king or e5.

05. FRENCH 3...B6

Course move: e5. Purpose: Exchange Black's active bishop and retain the space advantage. Engine comparison: 1. Nc3 Nf6 2. e5 Nfd7 3. Nce2 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Be7 (+0.48 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The a6 knight may reroute to b4 or c5 with tempo.

06. FRENCH EARLY ...C5

Course move: d5. Purpose: Use the space and advanced passer while completing development. Engine comparison: 1. d5 exd5 2. exd5 d6 3. Bd3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Nbd7 5. c4 Qe7+ (+0.71 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The d6 pawn can become blockaded and weak.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. FRENCH TARRASCH ALTERNATIVE

Course move: Nd2. Purpose: Understand a flexible alternative that avoids the Winawer pin. Engine comparison: 1. Nc3 Nf6 2. e5 Nfd7 3. Nce2 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Be7 (+0.48 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The d4 pawn remains Black's target.

08. FRENCH EXCHANGE AWARENESS

Course move: exd5. Purpose: Use active piece placement to create imbalance in a symmetrical structure. Engine comparison: 1. Nc3 Nf6 2. e5 Nfd7 3. Nce2 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Be7 (+0.48 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Routine symmetry can surrender the initiative.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.